

Rules of the Universe (Operational Logic)

To run *Zero Sum* effectively, players and GMs must understand the fundamental rules of the 2026 modern world. If you break these rules, the system will crush you.

1. Digital Footprints are Permanent

- **The Rule:** Everything connected to the internet leaves a log. Every credit card swipe, toll booth pass, facial recognition camera, and cell tower ping is recorded.
- **The Consequence:** You cannot just "delete" a video or "hack the mainframe." To erase data, you must either physically destroy the servers holding the backups or corrupt the data pool so heavily that the truth is indistinguishable from noise.

2. Violence Escalates Asymmetrically

- **The Rule:** If you shoot someone, the state will bring its full weight down upon you. You cannot out-gun a SWAT team or a private military contractor.
- **The Consequence:** Violence must be the absolute last resort, used only to break contact and escape. If the players engage in a prolonged firefight, they are guaranteed to lose.

3. The Power of "Parallel Construction"

- **The Rule:** Intelligence agencies often find out what they want to know using illegal surveillance. To use it in court without revealing their methods, they use "parallel construction"—tipping off local police to pull someone over for a broken taillight, allowing them to "discover" the evidence legally.

- **The Consequence:** If the players think they have covered their tracks but are suddenly arrested for a minor, unrelated crime, it means the conspiracy has found them and is trying to neutralize them "by the book." However, this is an active battleground. If players can mechanically prove the traffic stop was orchestrated by an intelligence agency, they expose the "Fruit of the Poisonous Tree" and the local charges will collapse under legal scrutiny.
- **Mechanical GM Checks (Parallel Construction in Play):** When characters leave digital footprints (e.g., failing a hacking roll, using flagged communications, or neglecting to secure their devices), the GM should not immediately dispatch tactical squads. Instead, the GM rolls a **Parallel Construction Check**:
- **Dice Pool:** The GM rolls a pool of D10s equal to the group's current **Heat Level + the number of distinct digital infractions/compromises** (maximum pool of 10).
- **Difficulty Class (DC):** The DC depends on the surveillance infrastructure of the characters' current location:
 - *Dense Panopticon (e.g., smart cities, corporate headquarters, intelligence hubs):* DC 1 (only 1 success needed).
 - *Standard Net (e.g., major cities, transportation terminals):* DC 2.
 - *Loose Net (e.g., rural areas, developing nations):* DC 3.
- **Resolution Outcomes:**
 - *1 Success:* Local authorities are tipped off via a fabricated anonymous call or automated flag. A patrol unit is dispatched to pull the characters over for a minor pretext (e.g., speeding, broken light) to perform an ID check and search.
 - *2 Successes:* The conspiracy fabricates probable cause. A warrant is generated in the national database, leading to a coordinated police arrest or safehouse raid under standard law enforcement protocols.
 - *3+ Successes:* Complete intelligence integration. Federal or corporate strike teams intercept the characters under the

guise of an urgent anti-terrorist or national security operation.

4. Trust is a Liability

- **The Rule:** Everyone has a pressure point. A beloved family member, a secret bank account, a hidden addiction. The conspiracy will find it and use it.
- **The Consequence:** Players must constantly compartmentalize information. If an ally doesn't need to know where the safehouse is, don't tell them. If an NPC gets captured, assume everything they know is compromised within 24 hours.

5. The Truth Doesn't Matter; Narrative Does

- **The Rule:** Having proof of a crime is useless if the public doesn't believe it. Deepfakes, AI-generated news, and bot farms can instantly discredit any leak.
- **The Consequence:** To "win" a campaign, it's not enough to just steal the encrypted drive. The players must find a way to disseminate the information securely and make it impossible for the media to ignore or spin. They have to hack the narrative, not just the network.

6. The Sovereign Void (Jurisdictional Labyrinths)

- **The Rule:** Westphalian national sovereignty is decaying into jurisdictional labyrinths. International waters, offshore tax havens, and Special Economic Zones (SEZs) are not lawless "blank spots"—the law exists, but it is entirely owned by the enemy.
- **The Consequence:** PMCs don't kill you because it's legally empty; they kill you because the ship flies a Bahamian flag of convenience, the PMC is registered to a shell company in the

Seychelles, and the local magistrate has been bought off. The void is a legal slaughterhouse engineered through loopholes.

7. Systemic Rot and Algorithmic White-Listing

- **The Rule:** The surveillance state is vast, but it is not omnipotent. It suffers from systemic rot. Intelligence agencies refuse to share facial recognition with corporate PMCs due to petty disputes, and cameras have blind spots because city councils embezzled the maintenance budgets.
- **The Consequence:** This is where players survive. Furthermore, the Factions use "Cryptographic White-Listing" to avoid their own systems. PMCs carry tokens that tell city acoustic sensors to ignore their gunfire. Enterprising players can steal or spoof these tokens to buy short windows of consequence-free violence.